More Forest Land May Not Fix Loggers' Biggest Problems

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President Trump is widely expected to soon open about 44 million **acres** of the country's last **pristine** national forests. He says this will bring **timber** jobs back to struggling small towns and help prevent wildfires in overgrown land. Last year, he signed actions to boost **timber** sales and reverse the **Roadless Rule**, which has blocked most new logging on undeveloped national forest land since 2001. But people who work in the forests say the problems are much bigger than getting more trees. Sean Smith, who runs Starfire Lumber in Cottage Grove, Oregon, says **diesel** fuel costs a record-high price, and steel, **sawblades** and other parts cost more too. Logger Jeff Brink says few people want to wake at 2 a.m. and drive a log truck for about the same pay as working at McDonald's. Experts say opening the forests may raise federal **timber** sales by only five to ten percent.

Word Treasure

pristine -- Pristine means untouched and in its natural, original state.

timber -- Timber is wood from trees that is cut for building and other uses.

Roadless Rule -- The Roadless Rule is a rule that has blocked most new logging on undeveloped national forest land.

sawblades -- Sawblades are the sharp cutting parts of a saw.

diesel -- Diesel is a kind of fuel used to run trucks and heavy machines.

acres -- An acre is a unit used to measure a piece of land.

Background you need

National forests are large areas of forest land owned by the country, and logging means cutting trees there for wood.

A rule has blocked most new logging on undeveloped forest land, because roads and cutting change wild places.

Opening more land to logging could bring timber jobs to small towns, but workers say high fuel and equipment costs and a shortage of workers are bigger problems.

Break it down

WHO: President Trump, lumber manager Sean Smith, logger Jeff Brink, and forestry experts
WHAT: More national forest land may open to logging, but workers say costs and worker shortages are bigger problems
WHERE: National forests, including Cottage Grove, Oregon
WHY: Opening forests is meant to bring timber jobs back and prevent wildfires, but fuel and equipment costs are high and few people want the jobs

Why it matters

Forests, jobs, and wildfire safety shape the towns where some children live and the wild places they may visit.

Test what you remember

1. What land may soon be opened?

(A) Pristine national forests
(B) City parks
(C) Farm fields
(D) Desert dunes

2. What does President Trump say opening the forests will do?

(A) It will make diesel cheaper
(B) It will stop all rain
(C) It will bring timber jobs back and help prevent wildfires
(D) It will hire more teachers

3. What does Sean Smith say costs a record-high price?

(A) Timber jobs
(B) McDonald's meals
(C) Log trucks
(D) Diesel fuel

4. What does logger Jeff Brink say about driving a log truck?

(A) Everyone wants to drive log trucks
(B) Few people want to wake at 2 a.m. for about the same pay as working at McDonald's
(C) Drivers earn more than doctors
(D) Trucks drive themselves

5. By how much may opening the forests raise federal timber sales?

(A) Only five to ten percent
(B) By half
(C) By double
(D) Not at all

6. What is the Roadless Rule?

(A) A rule blocking most new logging on undeveloped national forest land
(B) A rule for driving log trucks
(C) A rule about building roads in cities
(D) A rule banning campfires

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: A 2: C 3: D 4: B 5: A 6: A

Questions to think about

1. President Trump: He says opening the forests will bring timber jobs back to struggling small towns and help prevent wildfires in overgrown land.

2. People who work in the forests: They say the problems are much bigger than getting more trees, pointing to high costs and few people willing to do the work.

3. Experts: They say opening the forests may raise federal timber sales by only five to ten percent.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):